The Song of the Unbound

A Monologue of Self-Realization

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Before the Song

These verses are spoken by one voice: someone who wandered, searched, stopped searching, and found that nothing had ever been missing.

It names no god, quotes no scripture, and keeps no ritual. It has no audience except whoever happens to overhear. If you overhear it, do not try to agree with it. Test each line against your own direct experience, here and now. Whatever survives the test is yours. Let the rest go.

I. What Is Left

1. When everything is taken away,
   what is left is what I am.
   Strip the name, strip the face, strip the story.
   Something is still here, clear as a cloudless noon.

2. I looked for myself in the body
   and found sensations coming and going.
   I looked for myself in the mind
   and found thoughts coming and going.

3. I looked for the one who was looking,
   and the looking turned around,
   and there was no one,
   and the no-one was full of light.

4. I am not this, I am not that.
   I am not the one who says "not this, not that."
   When the negations are finished,
   I remain without saying anything.

5. I am awake in waking.
   I am awake in dreaming.
   I am awake in sleep without dreams,
   though no one there remembers it.

6. The three states pass through me
   like travelers through an open gate.
   The gate does not walk with them.
   The gate does not close.

7. How can I describe myself?
   Words are made of things,
   and I am not a thing.
   Whatever I say, I am the one who knows it.

8. I am nearer than near, so you cannot see me.
   I am plainer than plain, so you cannot believe me.
   I am what you are looking with
   while you look for me.

9. No one gave me this.

No one could take it.
It was not earned and cannot be lost.
It is simply what is, before anything else is.

10. I sit, and I am free.
I walk, and I am free.
I weep, I laugh, I eat, I sleep,
and freedom does not notice any difference.

II. Without Stain

1. I am clean, and nothing ever touched me.
   The mud of the years did not touch me.
   Every shame I carried
   was carried by a shadow I mistook for myself.

2. What sin can the sky commit?
   What virtue can it earn?
   Birds fly through it, smoke rises through it, storms rage in it.
   The sky remains the sky.

3. I did terrible things, they say,
   and I did beautiful things.
   The body did them, the mind decided them.
   I watched, and I was not stained.

4. Do not hear this as an excuse.
   The body-mind still answers for its deeds in the world.
   It repairs what it breaks.
   But I, the knowing, was never broken.

5. Guilt was a heavy coat in summer.
   I wore it because I thought I was cold.
   Now I see the sun has always been shining.
   The coat falls by itself.

6. Pride was a crown of paper.
   I wore it to look taller than the others.
   There are no others, and there is no tall.
   The paper blows away in the wind.

7. Pure and impure are judgments of the mind.
   The mind sorts, it is its work.
   I do not sort. I hold the sorting
   as an ocean holds a fish.

8. A lamp shines on a jewel and on a corpse.
   It does not become precious.
   It does not become rotten.
   I am the lamp, and more than the lamp.

9. Let the world call me holy.

Let the world call me lost.
Both names are written on water.
I am the water.

III. Nowhere to Go

1. I walked a thousand roads to find the end of roads.
   Every road brought me back
   to this place, this breath,
   this ordinary moment I kept trying to escape.

2. I sat with many teachers.
   Some were wise and some were frauds.
   All of them, without knowing it,
   pointed back at me.

3. I read the old books until my eyes ached.
   The books were maps of a country
   I had been standing in
   the whole time I was reading.

4. Mountains, forests, temples, deserts:
   I went everywhere freedom was rumored to live.
   It lived in none of them.
   It came with me to all of them.

5. Now I stay where I am.
   Or I go wherever the feet go.
   It makes no difference.
   The one who goes has never moved.

6. A pilgrimage is a circle.
   You leave home to search,
   and at the end of the search
   you discover you never left home.

7. No path, no progress, no stages.
   The ladder leaned against nothing.
   I climbed it for years
   and found I had been on the ground.

8. If you want to find me, do not travel.
   If you want to find me, do not stay.
   Stop looking for a place,
   and see what every place appears in.

9. Here is not a location.

Now is not a time.
Here and now are names
for what I am.

IV. I Am Not the Doer

1. Hands work, and I do not work.
   Feet walk, and I do not walk.
   The tongue speaks, the mind plans,
   and I am the stillness in the middle of it all.

2. Things happen as rain happens.
   No one decides to rain.
   The clouds gather, the air cools,
   and the earth is wet.

3. Choices rise like that.
   A thought appears, a feeling leans,
   and then the deed is done.
   Where was the doer?

4. I looked for the doer for a long time.
   I found thoughts that claimed the deeds after they were done,
   like a rooster who believes
   his crowing makes the sun rise.

5. What a load fell from my shoulders
   when I stopped being the rooster!
   The sun rises anyway.
   I enjoy the morning.

6. Let the body earn, let it build, let it serve.
   Let it fail and try again.
   I do not hold its successes.
   I do not hold its ruins.

7. People ask, “Then why act at all?”
   Why does a river flow?
   Why does a flower open?
   Action is the world’s play. I am its stage.

8. I am not idle, though I do nothing.
   I am not busy, though everything is done.
   Stillness and movement are both my children.
   I love them equally.

9. The actor plays a beggar, a king, a fool.

He weeps real tears on the stage.
When the lamps go out,
he walks home as himself.

10. I am walking home while the play goes on.
I am home, and the play goes on.
There is no difference
between the stage and the house.

V. Unborn

1. They tell me I was born on a certain day.
   I believe them about the body.
   But I do not remember a beginning of knowing.
   I only remember knowing.

2. Before the body, was there darkness?
   Who saw the darkness?
   After the body, will there be darkness?
   Who will be there to see it?

3. The candle is lit and the candle burns out.
   Is the light that shows the candle
   lit with it?
   Does it go out with it?

4. I have died a thousand times already:
   the child died, the student died,
   the hopeful one, the bitter one, the seeker died.
   I am still here.

5. Each face I wore was buried,
   and I did not attend the funerals.
   I was too busy being the space
   the new face appeared in.

6. Death is the last change of clothes.
   I will watch it the way I watched the others,
   with curiosity, and perhaps fear,
   and underneath the fear, an unmoved clarity.

7. Do not pity me when the body falls.
   Do not mourn me as if I left.
   Look at the knowing in your own eyes.
   That is where I have always been.

8. I am not eternal, for eternal is a length of time.
   I am not momentary, for moments are counted.
   I am before counting.
   I am what every clock ticks inside.

9. Unborn, I have no parents,

though this body honors its mother and father.
Undying, I have no heirs,
though everything is my child.

VI. One Without a Second

1. I looked at the world and saw many.
   Mountains and ants, cities and stars,
   friends and strangers, lovers and enemies.
   Many, many, many.

2. Then I looked at the looking,
   and it was one.
   Every mountain appeared in the same light.
   Every enemy was lit by my own clarity.

3. Then I looked again,
   and there was no “one” either,
   for “one” needs a “two” to be counted against.
   There was simply this, without a number.

4. Not two: this is all I can say.
   The seer and the seen are not two.
   The knower and the known are not two.
   The lover and the beloved are not two.

5. The wave and the ocean are not two.
   The ring and the gold are not two.
   The pot and the clay are not two.
   I and the world are not two.

6. Then what is the world?
   My own face, seen in a mirror without edges.
   What am I?
   The world, before it is named.

7. When I hear thunder, it is my voice.
   When I see a child running, it is my joy.
   When I see a man starving, it is my hunger.
   There is nowhere to hide from this.

8. Some think non-duality makes the heart cold.
   It makes the heart unbearably warm.
   No wall is left
   to keep the world’s pain outside.

9. So I help where I can help.

Not as a saint helping sinners,
not as the rich helping the poor,
but as a hand that lifts the foot that stumbled.

VII. The Seeker Laid Down

1. I was a seeker for many years.
   I wore the seeking like a badge.
   I was proud of my hunger,
   proud of how far I had come.

2. The seeker was the last thing to go.
   It would let go of wealth, of comfort, of reputation,
   but it would not let go of itself.
   It wanted to be there when freedom arrived.

3. Freedom does not arrive for anyone.
   When the seeker is finally tired,
   when it lies down like a dog at evening,
   what was always here is simply noticed.

4. I do not seek anymore.
   Not because I have found,
   but because there was never anything apart from me
   to be found.

5. The hunter hunted his own footprints.
   The thief searched his own pockets.
   The fish swam the whole sea
   looking for water.

6. Now I laugh at the old striving.
   Not cruelly, but tenderly,
   as one smiles at a child
   who covers his eyes and believes he is hidden.

7. If the seeking returns, let it return.
   It is only an old habit visiting.
   I give it tea.
   It leaves when it is ready.

8. Practices were useful once.
   Now they come and go as they please.
   Sometimes I sit in silence, sometimes I do not.
   Silence sits in me either way.

VIII. On Thought and Feeling

1. Thoughts come to me like the sound of traffic.
   Some are loud, some are faint.
   I do not need to follow them.
   I do not need to silence them.

2. A memory rises: someone wronged me long ago.
   The chest tightens. The jaw sets.
   I watch it all, a little storm in a teacup,
   and the teacup is held in a vast open hand.

3. A hope rises: the future could be wonderful.
   The heart lifts. Plans begin to sprout.
   Let them sprout.
   I am not the garden. I am the ground.

4. Sorrow comes, and I let it be sorrow.
   I do not wrap it in spiritual words.
   I do not tell it, "You are an illusion."
   I let it weep, and I hold the weeping.

5. Joy comes, and I let it be joy.
   I do not grasp it.
   It came without my effort.
   It will leave without my permission.

6. Anger burns through like a brush fire.
   Let it burn out, and harm no one.
   The field is blackened, then green again.
   The earth beneath the field is untouched.

7. Fear whispers: "You are small, you will be crushed."
   I listen to the whisper with interest.
   Who is small?
   Where is the edge of me?

8. The mind is a radio left on in the next room.
   Sometimes I listen to the song.
   Sometimes I forget it is playing.
   I am never inside the radio.

9. Feelings are weather. I am the sky.

The sky does not fight the rain.
The sky does not pray for sunshine.
The sky is wide enough for everything.

IX. Among People

1. I walk in the marketplace.
   Sellers shout, buyers argue, children run between legs.
   All of it is happening in me.
   None of it is happening to me.

2. Someone praises me, and I smile.
   Someone insults me, and I smile.
   The smile is not a mask.
   It is the face of someone with nothing to defend.

3. I do not need anyone to understand this.
   I do not need disciples.
   If someone asks, I answer.
   If no one asks, I am silent and content.

4. I honor my mother and my father.
   I honor the stranger at the gate.
   I see the same light in their eyes
   that shines in mine.

5. Some call me strange.
   Some call me lazy.
   Some call me wise.
   I am not what they call me. I hear it all with a quiet heart.

6. I do not judge the drunk, the thief, or the liar.
   I see the hunger that moves them,
   the same hunger that once moved me:
   the hunger to be whole.

7. I do not approve of harm.
   I will stand between the knife and the child.
   But I will do it without hatred,
   because the one holding the knife is not my enemy.

8. A friend comes and cries on my shoulder.
   I do not lecture them about illusion.
   I hold them.
   That is the whole teaching.

9. The world is full of my family.

Some of them do not know it yet.
It does not matter.
I know.

X. Wealth and Power

1. Gold came into my hands and left again.
   I did not grow larger when it came.
   I did not grow smaller when it left.
   I counted the coins, and the counter was not counted.

2. The body needs food and shelter.
   Let it work honestly and earn them.
   Let it build something useful for others.
   But do not think the earnings are a ladder to me.

3. I saw people climb high on the backs of others.
   I saw them seize power and money that was not theirs.
   I saw them fall.
   They were looking for me in the wrong place.

4. They wanted to be secure.
   They wanted no one ever to look down on them again.
   They thought a mountain of gold
   would finally be enough.

5. No mountain is enough
   for one who thinks they are small.
   No crumb is too little
   for one who knows they are whole.

6. Power is a sharp tool.
   It cuts the hand that grips it too hard.
   Hold it lightly, if it comes.
   Give it away as soon as the work is done.

7. The one who steals from others steals from himself.
   This is not a moral rule.
   It is plain sight.
   There is only one pocket in the universe.

8. I do not despise money.
   I do not worship it.
   It is a river that waters fields.
   Let it flow through honest hands.

9. Rich or poor, I am the same.

Famous or forgotten, I am the same.
Let the body live simply or grandly.
I live in neither the palace nor the hut.

XI. Free of All Teachings

1. I give you no rules.
   Rules are fences for those who fear they will wander.
   Where could you wander?
   Every direction leads back to here.

2. I give you no beliefs.
   Beliefs are bridges over a river you think you must cross.
   You are already on the other side.
   You were always the river and both shores.

3. Even this song is not a teaching.
   It is the sound a bell makes when it is struck.
   The bell does not teach.
   It rings, and the ringing fades.

4. If any word here becomes a chain,
   throw it away.
   If this whole book becomes an idol,
   burn it in your mind.

5. Truth is not in books.
   Truth is what reads them.
   Truth is not in teachers.
   Truth is what listens to them.

6. Freedom is not the property of a tradition.
   It is not owned by monks or by mystics.
   It belongs to the farmer, the merchant, the child, the dying.
   It belongs to no one, because it is what everyone is.

7. Do not become a follower of non-duality.
   A follower needs a leader.
   Two have appeared again.
   Look once more.

8. Do not become proud of being awake.
   Pride is the dream reaching up to wear the crown of waking.
   The awake are ordinary.
   The awake do the dishes.

XII. The Wanderer's Song

1. I wander, and I go nowhere.
   I rest, and I am not still.
   I speak, and silence is not broken.
   I am silent, and everything is said.

2. The road under my feet is mine.
   The sky over my head is mine.
   Nothing is mine.
   I am all of it, and I own nothing.

3. I have no country, though the body has a home.
   I have no tribe, though the heart has family.
   I have no faith, though I bow to every sincere prayer.
   I am before countries, tribes, and faiths were named.

4. Morning comes, and I am the morning.
   Rain falls, and I am the rain.
   A dog barks in the distance,
   and I am the listening and the bark.

5. Let them seek me in temples and towers.
   Let them seek me in mountains and books.
   I am in the dust on their sandals,
   in the breath that carries their prayers.

6. I am not wise. I am not foolish.
   I am not holy. I am not lost.
   I am not anything you can name.
   And I am everything you name.

7. Wonder! Wonder!
   Nothing was ever bound.
   Nothing was ever freed.
   And this, just this, is enough.

8. I bow to no one, and I bow to all.
   I am bowing, and no one bows.
   The bow is the whole universe
   folding gently into itself.

9. If you hear this song,

do not follow the singer.
Turn around,
and find the silence you are hearing it in.

10. There I am.
There you are.
Not two.

A Note for the Reader

This monologue is a companion to *The Song of What Remains*. That book is a dialogue between a seeker and a teacher. This one is a single voice speaking after the search has ended, in the spirit of the *Avadhuta Gita*: the free wanderer singing to no one in particular.

Like its companion, it leaves out every god, scripture, ritual, and technical term on purpose, so that anyone can test it against their own experience. Every verse is new writing.

The same caution applies. Non-dual insight never cancels responsibility. A person who has truly seen that there is "only one pocket in the universe" becomes more honest and more caring, never less. If a line here ever seems to excuse harm, it has been misread.